

The Biggest World Cup Ever Is Coming -- and It's Right in Our Backyard!

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Have you ever kicked a soccer ball and dreamed of scoring the winning goal in the World Cup? Well, get ready, because the biggest World Cup ever is about to kick off and it's happening right here in North America! For the first time since 1994, the FIFA Men's World Cup returns to our continent, spread across the United States, Mexico, and Canada. But this one is extra special: it's the first World Cup with 48 teams instead of 32. That means more countries, more matches, and more chances for amazing moments. The **tournament** starts on June 11, 2026, at the famous **Estadio Azteca** in Mexico City, where Mexico will play the opening game. Over 39 days, teams will battle through 104 matches in 16 different cities: 11 in the U.S., three in Mexico, and two in Canada. The final showdown happens on July 19 at MetLife Stadium in New Jersey. Here's how it works: the 48 teams are split into 12 groups of four. Each team plays the other three in its group once. A win gets you three points, a tie (called a **draw**) gets one, and a loss gets zero. The top two teams from each group move on that's 24 teams. But wait! The eight best third-place teams also sneak into the next round, making it a total of 32 teams. From there, it's **knockout** time. Lose once, and you're out. If a game is tied after 90 minutes, they play 30 more. Still tied? It goes to a **penalty shootout** a super-tense contest where players take turns trying to score one-on-one against the goalkeeper. The champion will be crowned on July 19. Can Argentina win **back-to-back** titles, or will a new hero emerge? Grab your jersey and get ready to cheer!

Word Treasure

tournament -- A series of games in which teams try to win a championship.

draw -- When a game ends with both teams having the same score, also called a tie.

knockout -- A stage where losing one match means you are out of the competition.

penalty shootout -- A way to break a tie where players take turns kicking from a spot against the goalkeeper.

back-to-back -- Winning two championships in a row.

Estadio Azteca -- A famous soccer stadium in Mexico City that has hosted World Cup finals before.

Background you need

FIFA (the international governing body for soccer) holds the World Cup every four years, and in 2022 Argentina, led by Lionel Messi, won the tournament.

Estadio Azteca in Mexico City (the stadium where the opening game will be) is historic because it hosted World Cup finals in 1970 and 1986.

This World Cup is special because it expands from 32 to 48 teams, allowing more countries from around the world to join.

Break it down

WHO: Players from 48 national teams, FIFA organizers, and fans across the world.

WHAT: The 2026 FIFA Men's World Cup, a soccer tournament with 104 matches, will determine the world champion.

WHERE: 16 cities across the United States, Mexico, and Canada; the opening match is at Estadio Azteca in Mexico City, and the final at MetLife Stadium in New Jersey.

WHY: The tournament is the biggest in soccer, and this edition includes more teams than ever to celebrate the sport's global popularity.

Why it matters

This World Cup is the biggest soccer party on the planet, and with games in our own country, you might experience the excitement of different cultures coming together right in your backyard.

Test what you remember

1. How many teams will play in the 2026 World Cup?

- ☐ (A) 32
- ☐ (B) 48
- ☐ (C) 64
- ☐ (D) 24

2. Where is the opening match being held?

- ☐ (A) MetLife Stadium
- ☐ (B) Estadio Azteca
- ☐ (C) Los Angeles
- ☐ (D) Toronto

3. How many points does a team get for a win in the group stage?

- ☐ (A) 1
- ☐ (B) 2
- ☐ (C) 3
- ☐ (D) 0

4. What happens if a knockout game is still tied after 120 minutes?

- ☐ (A) Extra time again
- ☐ (B) Penalty shootout
- ☐ (C) The team with more corners wins
- ☐ (D) A coin toss

5. When is the final match?

- ☐ (A) June 11
- ☐ (B) July 19
- ☐ (C) August 3
- ☐ (D) December 18

6. Which country is the defending champion going into the 2026 tournament?

- ☐ (A) France
- ☐ (B) Brazil
- ☐ (C) Argentina
- ☐ (D) Germany

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Positive:** Many fans are thrilled because more teams mean more exciting matches and the chance to see underdog countries succeed.
2. **Critical:** Some people worry that the expansion to 48 teams might water down the quality of play and make the tournament less competitive.
3. **Neutral:** Hosting the event in three countries is a huge logistical challenge, but it also spreads the economic benefits across North America.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):